

OPINION

The Navy is launching a major redevelopment project, and many San Diegans aren't paying attention

The Navy has proposed five alternatives for the 70-acre site along Interstate 5, and four would greatly impact the local community.



By **PHILLIP HALPERN**

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***Halpern** was an assistant U.S. attorney for 36 years in the U.S. Attorney's Office in San Diego. He is a resident of Mission Hills.*

The U.S. Navy has [embraced](#) "stealth" technology with the launch of three Zumwalt class warships. This technology allows the ships to elude radar, sail into enemy territory undetected and conduct surveillance in a clandestine manner. Such stealth strategies are, of course, both necessary and laudable when undertaken in the national interest.

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Unfortunately, the Navy has also recently launched a stealthy redevelopment project, which has been flying under the radar of most San Diego residents. This project — which is shamefully supported by the city of San Diego — seeks to modernize the old SPAWAR site (a collection of buildings alongside Pacific Highway just east of Old Town) and the Navy's Old Town campus (a contiguous area running along Midway Drive). The cost: destruction of the very quality of life we all prize in living, working and vacationing in this beautiful city.

These two properties (collectively named NAVWAR) comprise more than 70 acres spanning almost a mile along Interstate 5 and falling on both sides of Pacific Highway. The Navy has proposed five alternatives for the site, which vary greatly in their impact upon the local community.

Alternative 1 — which the Navy appears to dismiss out of hand — would be funded entirely by the Navy and simply require renovating the existing buildings.

Alternatives 2 and 3 would call for public-private mixed-use developments. The few existing buildings would be demolished and approximately 100 buildings would be built in their place. These buildings would dwarf the normal 30-foot coastal limit and be as high as 240 feet (22 or so stories).

Alternatives 4 and 5 — which the Navy and city officials are pushing — are even worse. These would replace the existing NAVWAR buildings with as many as 109 new edifices, including 35 high-rise buildings that would be as tall as 350 feet (more than 30 stories) and encompass millions of square feet of commercial, hotel and residential space.

Even under the Navy's most rosy predictions, these latter alternatives would take 30 years to complete and result in an additional 70,000 daily vehicle trips, leading in the interim to major traffic slowdowns on Interstate 8, Interstate 5 and State Route 163 — as well as 26 surrounding intersections and streets. The Navy estimates that the Interstate 5 northbound onramp at Old Town Avenue would experience staggering lines of over 500 cars long during rush hours with wait times more than [1½ hours](#). Either no one in the Navy has lately traveled on these already jam-packed roads or, more likely, it simply doesn't care if it turns our town into another Los Angeles.

The Navy also blithely notes that the area's air quality would likely diminish, and the project's visual impact would be "significant and unavoidable" affecting "19 historic properties located within a half-mile." This appalling admission is made with full recognition that the Navy's proposed project would completely transform and disfigure the character of several of our tourist and cultural jewels.

Presidio Park is located directly across from the proposed redevelopment. The park features 40 acres of green open space, picnic areas and memorials commemorating both the original Kumeyaay inhabitants and California's early European settlers. The marvelous views of the surrounding landscape, Pacific Ocean, Mission Bay and San Diego River Valley draw both tourists and San Diego natives year-round. It is a frequent spot for family getaways and a favorite locale for wedding photos.

All alternatives (with the exception of alternative 1) will permanently blemish the character of this park. Indeed, without even considering the increased traffic and noise, the proposed high-rise structures will tower over the park, casting a shadow over its tranquility and beauty, and despoiling its famous views.

The effect on historic Old Town would be even more calamitous. Rather than providing a glimpse into colonial life in San Diego, the proposed project will surely become an apt avatar symbolizing the destruction of our city's charm by modern overdevelopment. The Navy should no more be allowed to build its project at this location than it should be allowed to build it next to Williamsburg, Virginia, or Salem, Massachusetts.

The only real benefit the Navy and city offer for this absurd project is a new rapid transit hub, which they refer to as "San Diego's Grand Central Station." But the new hub would be located less than a mile from the Old Town transit hub and three miles from Downtown. And it would still lack a rail connection to the airport, Pacific Beach, Ocean Beach or La Jolla. Rather than a Grand Central Station, it will be more like an Unnecessary Auxiliary Station.

If San Diego is to live up to its reputation as America's Finest City, the Navy simply cannot be allowed to adopt Alternatives 2-5. The sensible solution is Alternative 1 (renovating the existing buildings and imposing a reasonable height limitation), which would result in the city paying no additional money. This option also honors the Navy's rich history and role in shaping San Diego and its many contributions to the region's economic prosperity, history and culture.

The Navy is accepting public comments for the project through Aug. 12. Visit navwar-revitalization.com to submit one via its website.

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